

**From Demonstrative to Discourse:
the cartographic footprint of *gam2* in Cantonese**

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Abstract

The current study examines two less discussed usages of the demonstrative *gam2* in Cantonese. In addition to its adverbial and clausal usages, I argue that *gam2* can be used as an event-type SFP for kind establishment, and *gam2joeng2* can be used as a tag statement for self-confirmation. I also depict the grammaticalization path of *gam2* and *gam2joeng2*. I show that the two differs in terms of the directionality of grammaticalization.

Keywords

Demonstratives, sentence-final particles, tag statements, grammaticalization, Cantonese

1. Introduction

Cross-linguistically, demonstratives are used to “point at” different ontological types anaphorically/deictically (Dissel 1999, Anderson & Morzycki 2015, König & Umbach 2018). Examples of Cantonese nominal demonstratives are given in Table 1.¹

	<i>Nominal demonstratives</i>		
Antecedent	Entity	Time	Place
Form	<i>ni1/go2-go3</i>	<i>ni1/go2-paai4</i>	<i>ni1/go2-dou6</i>
Gloss	this/that-CL	these/those-days	here/there

Table 1: Nominal demonstratives in Cantonese (cf. Cheung 2007, Matthews & Yip 2011)

Adverbial demonstratives receive limited attention but are equally common in Cantonese (see Peng 2003, Sio & Tang 2007, 2008, Cheung 2013, Lai & Wu 2020), with different distributions and interpretations. Examples are given in Table 2.

	<i>Adverbial demonstratives</i>		
Antecedent	Degree	Manner	Quality
Form	<i>gam3-Adj</i>	<i>gam2-V</i>	<i>gam2-N</i>
Gloss	this/that	like this/that	such

¹ Cantonese examples are transcribed in *Jyutping* (the Linguistic Society of Hong Kong Cantonese Romanization Scheme, 1993). Tones are represented when necessary.

Table 2: Adverbial demonstratives in Cantonese (cf. Cheung 2007, Sio & Tang 2007)

They are not anaphoric to nominals, and they appear before verbs or adjectives. As in many other languages, the one for degree, *gam3* in (1a), is different from the one for manner and quality, *gam2* in (1b) and (1c) (Arsenijević et al. 2015, Lai & Wu 2020).

(1) Adverbial demonstratives in Cantonese

- a. Tiu sing jau saam-mai **gam3** coeng. (Sio & Tang 2007, (55))
 CL rope have three-meter GAM3 long
 ‘The rope is three meters long.’
- b. Koei **gam2** zou-je m dak gaa3. (Sio & Tang 2007, (1))
 S/he GAM2 do-thing not possible SFP
 ‘He/She working in such a way is not acceptable.’
- c. Lok jyu **gam2** seng (Cheung 2007, p.99)
 fall rain GAM2 sound
 ‘(It) sounds like rainfall’

Only *gam2*, but not *gam3*, can be used as a clausal demonstrative. In this usage, *gam2* can appear in a predicate or an argument position, as in (2a) and (2b), respectively.

	<i>Clausal demonstratives</i>	
Antecedent	Property	Proposition
Form	<i>gam2</i>	<i>gam2</i>
Gloss	like this/that	that/so

Table 3: Clausal demonstratives in Cantonese (cf. Cheung 2007, Sio & Tang 2007)

(2) Clausal demonstratives in Cantonese

- a. Peter hai **gam2** gaa3. (Sio & Tang 2007, (51))
 Peter be GAM2 SFP
 ‘Peter is like that.’
- b. **Gam2** m hai gei hou gwaa3. (Peng 2003, (6))
 GAM2 not be quite good SFP
 ‘This is not quite good, perhaps.’

This paper focuses on two less discussed usages of *gam2*, both of which appear sentence-finally and perform discourse-related functions, exemplified in (3). I refer to these two usages as SFP *gam2* and tag *gam2joeng2*, respectively.^{2 3}

(3) a. SFP *gam2* (Peng 2003, (10))

Ngo soeng lai bong-haa sau **gam2** ze1.

I want come help-DEL help GAM2 SFP.

‘I just want to come help, *or something like that.*’

b. Tag *gam2joeng2* (Luke 2000, (46))

Gam2 ne zau jiu soksoeng seisapng-maan ge2 **gam2joeng2**.

GAM2 TOP then need claim 450.thousands SFP GAM2JOENG2

‘If so, (we) need to make a claim for 450 thousand dollars. *That’s it.*’

This paper is organized as follows. Section 2 discusses the SFP status of *gam2* and its interpretation. Section 3 moves on to its usage as a tag statement and discourse functions. Section 4 depicts the grammaticalization paths of these two usages. Section 5 concludes with remarks.

2. *Gam2* as an event-type SFP

2.1. The distribution of SFP *gam2*

Following the classification of SFPs in Tang (2015, 2020) in (4), I argue that *gam2* is an event-type SFP. This is supported by two observations. First, SFP *gam2* occurs before the other four types of SFPs, as illustrated in (5)-(8).⁴

(4) The ordering of SFPs in Cantonese

Event < Temporal < Focus < Degree(modality, interrogative, imperative) < Call on Address

² Following Cheung (2013), I treat *gam2* and its variants, including *gam2-joeng2* ‘so-appearance’ and *gam2-joeng2-joeng2* ‘so-appearance-appearance’ to be identical. To the best of my knowledge, these forms are interchangeable in all the cases in (1)-(3). There is no detectable change in meaning either. Given that the SFP usage is usually realized as *gam2*, and the tag usage is usually realized as *gam2joeng2*, I follow this convention in the rest of the paper.

³ In (3), I translate *gam2* as ‘or something like that’ and *gam2joeng2* as ‘that’s it’ for illustrative purposes, but the translation is at best impressionistic. Given the subtle nature of the meanings, there is no natural counterpart in English. The exact nature of their meaning will be discussed in section 2 and section 3, respectively. In all following examples, I leave out the translations of *gam2(joeng2)*.

⁴ Examples (5)-(7) are from the following sources:

(5): <http://www.cse.cuhk.edu.hk/~lyu/student/fyp99/lyu9904/s977241/home4.1/4-00.html>

(6): <https://m.edu-kingdom.com/post.php?fid=&tid=250851&page=100>

(7): <http://iceefaery.blogspot.com/2017/02/blog-post.html>

(5) *Gam2* < SFP_{temporal}

Gamgoksoeng go daaihok sangngaai dou jyun-zo **gam2** laa3.
 feel.like CL college life DOU finish-PFV GAM2 SFP_{temporal}
 ‘(I) feel like the college life is already over.’

(6) *Gam2* < SFP_{focus}

Zihai man-haa go neoi hai hokhaau jau-mou faatsang di me si
 only ask-del CL daughter at school have-not happen CL what thing
 lingdou keoi m soeng faanhok **gam2** zaa3.
 make her not soeng go.to.school GAM2 SFP_{focus}
 ‘(I) only asked my daughter if anything happens and makes her doesn’t go to
 school, something like that.’

(7) *Gam2* < SFP_{degree (modality)}

Ningei jau daai-zo **gam2** gwaa3
 age again get.bigger-PFV GAM2 SFP_{modality}
 ‘Perhaps (I am) getting older again.’

(8) *Gam2* < SFP_{Call on Addressee}

Nei soeng lai bong-haa sau **gam2** ↗ ?
 you want come help-DEL help GAM2 SFP_{Call on Addressee}
 ‘You want to come and help?’

Second, when compared to event-type SFPs, the relative order of SFP *gam2* suggests that it is best regarded as a member of this type. It precedes the additive *tim1* (as in (9)), but it follows excessive *mat1zai6* and delimitive *haa5* (as in (10)).⁵

(9) *Gam2* precedes *tim1*

Keoidei ge zyunzoi go-go dou zi, zung dosiu zidou keoidei ge
 they GE existence CL-CL all know also some know they GE
 sizik **gam2** tim1.
 deed GAM2 SFP
 ‘Everyone knows their existence, and also their deeds too.’

⁵ Examples (10-11) are from the following sources:

(9): http://iceefaery.blogspot.com/2017/09/blog-post_5.html

(10a), modified:

https://www.facebook.com/photo.php?fbid=681606687307502&id=100063745298824&set=a.124062049728638&locale=zh_HK

(10b): <https://www.hkepc.com/forum/viewthread.php?fid=135&tid=1552638&page=2341>

(10) Gam2 follows mat1zai6 and haa5

- a. Kyut waitaiming D wui tai-m-hei-ging mat1zai6 **gam2** lo1.
 lack Vitamin D will feel.unmotivated SFP GAM2 SFP
 ‘The lack of Vitamin D will (make one) feel unmotivated.’
- b. Minfai dinsi jipzik giuzou gin-dak haa5 **gam2**.
 Free TV performance be.said see-able SFP GAM2
 ‘The performance of free TV channels can be said to be just about acceptable.’

Interestingly, SFP *gam2* cannot co-occur with SFP *sin1* ‘first’, regardless of the relative order, as indicated in (11). This follows if *gam2* and *sin1* compete for the same syntactic position.

(11) Gam2 competes with sin1

- a. *Nei aai-zyu bui jejam {**gam2** sin1/ sin1 **gam2**} laa1.
 you order CL drink GAM2 SFP SFP GAM2 SFP
 Int.: ‘(Why don’t) you order a drink first.’
- b. *Keoi houginci jiu sai gonzeng zek sau {**gam2** sin1/ sin1 **gam2**}.
 s/he insist need wash clean CL hand GAM2 SFP SFP GAM2
 Int.: ‘S/he insisted that (one) should clean his/her hands first.’

As pointed out in Tang (2006b), event-type *sin1* can be embedded in relative clauses and subordinate clauses, as shown in (12).

(12) Event-type sin1 in embedded clauses

- a. [Zou gungfo **sin1**] ge sailouzai zeoi gwaai. (Tang 2006b, (65))
 do homework SFP GE child most good
 ‘Children who do (their) homework first are the best.’
- b. [Janwai keoi gung-zo **sin1**] ngo mou dak gong. (Tang 2006b, (66))
 because s/he say- PFV SFP I not able say
 ‘Because s/he said (it) first, I have no chance to say (it).’

It is thus predicted that SFP *gam2* can be embedded in these clauses as well. This is borne out in (13) and (14).

(13) Gam2 in relative and noun complement clauses

- a. [houci gainaa **gam2**] ge zi (Cheung 2007, p.99, modified)
 look.like hen GAM2 GE character
 ‘The character that looks like a hen (= is huge)’
- b. [loeng-gungpo aaigaau **gam2**] ge si (Cheung 2007, p.99)
 two-married.couple quarrel GAM2 GE issue
 ‘The issue of quarrels between a married couple’

(14) *Gam2* in subordinate clauses

- a. [Jyugwo sik siusiu jatman **gam2**], hoji zaapban.
if know a.bit Japanese GAM2 can join.class.midway
'If (you) know a bit Japanese, (you) can join a class midway.'
- b. [Janwai keoi wui ceot di je bei nei tai **gam2**], soji
because it will display some thing give you see GAM2 so
dou m wui taai mun.
DOU not will very boring.
'Because it will show you something, it won't be too boring.'

As such, the sentence-final *gam2* is best regarded as an SFP of the event-type, which occupies a relative low position compared to other SFPs.⁶

2.2. The interpretation of SFP *gam2*

2.2.1. *Not apposition*

Regarding the interpretation of SFP *gam2*, Peng (2003) notes in passing that *gam2* is anaphoric to the previous proposition, giving rise to some emphasis effect. This can be linked to the core function adverbial *gam2*. As pointed in Cheung (2007, p.99), examples like (13) involve an apposition structure. In particular, *gam2* occupies the same position as the preceding elements, to which *gam2* is anaphoric. Note that apposition is also possible in the nominal domain, as shown in (15).

- (15) [Siuwai **li go meng**] houci housuk gam2.
Siu Wai this CL name seem familiar GAM2
'The name Siu Wai seems familiar.' (Matthews & Yip 2011, p.108)

Applying this idea to SFP *gam2*, *gam2* in the relevant cases can be regarded as a clausal anaphor, whose semantic contribution is minimal, like its variants. Appealing as it may seem, this cannot be the full story of SFP *gam2*. As critically observed in Lee (2018), SFP *gam2* can appear in interrogative clauses.

(16) *Gam2* in interrogative sentences (Lee 2018, (30b), (33b))

- a. Zoengsaam hai-m-hai maai-zo go bun syu **gam2** aa3?
Zoengsaam be-not-be buy-PFV that CL book GAM2 SFP
'Did Zoengsaam buy that book?' (Polar questions)
- b. Zoengsaam sik-zo di me **gam2** aa3?
Zoengsaam eat-PFV CL.PL what GAM2 SFP
'What did Zoengsaam eat then?' (Constituent questions)

⁶ It is beyond the scope of this paper to discuss the precise syntactic position of *gam2*. The discussion is compatible with the view that *gam2* is an SFP in the TP domain or in the low CP domain.

If we follow the apposition approach to *gam2*, one must assume that *gam2* can be anaphoric to an interrogative clause. However, this assumption is not warranted. Consider (17a), which consists of a matrix declarative clause, and an embedded interrogative clause. In contrast to (17c), the use of *gam2* in (17b), is infelicitous, attributable to the fact that the predicate in (17b) requires an interrogative clause as its subject, and *gam2* fails to be anaphoric to the embedded clause in (17a).

(17) *Gam2* cannot be anaphoric to interrogative clauses

- a. Aaming soengzidou Aafan sik-zo di me.
Aaming wonder Aafan eat-PFV CL what
'Aaming wonders what Aafan ate.'
- b. #**Gam2** hai jat go houzungjiu ge mantai.
GAM2 be one CL important GE question
Int.: 'This (=what Aafan ate) is an important question.'
- c. **Gam2** hai jat gin housi.
GAM2 be one CL good.thing
'This (=Aaming wonders what Aafan ate) is a good thing.'

The idea that *gam2* develops usages that go beyond an anaphor introducing an apposition structure is not new in the literature. Indeed, Peng (2003) and Sio & Tang (2007, 2008) have argued that at least in some cases *gam2* has developed into a structural particle that introduces a manner adverb, whose presence becomes obligatory. An example is given in (18), showing that *gam2* is not mere an anaphor.

- (18) Ngodei [lap seng m ceot] *(**gam2**) haang. (Peng 2003, (18))
we CL sound not make GAM2 walk
'We walk without making a noise.'

2.2.2. *SFP gam2 establishes kinds of worlds*

As an alternative to the apposition approach to SFP *gam2*, I argue that *gam2* develops a non-anaphoric usage in the clause-final position. In particular, I propose that SFP *gam2* takes its preceding clause as its antecedent and refers to some state of affairs. Importantly, it expresses similarity to its antecedent and establishes *ad-hoc* kinds of worlds.⁷ The proposal represents a natural extension of the ideas in Carlson (1977), Gehrke (2011), Umbach & Gust (2014), Anderson & Morzycki (2015), who suggest that the primary function of demonstratives is to establish kinds. Anderson & Morzycki (2015) observe that "the connections between kinds, manners, and degrees are too systematic and too widespread to be accidental and suggest a profound similarity

⁷ Umbach & Gust (2014) argues that demonstratives establish *ad-hoc* kinds within the context, rather than well-established kinds. They are heavily context-sensitive.

among these domains.” (p.800). In favor of this idea, Arsenijević et al. (2015) also argue that the unification finds support in Sino-Tibetan languages (including Cantonese). It is thus possible to have a unified understanding of demonstratives by considering the respective kinds established by different types of demonstratives. (19) illustrates this idea with Cantonese *gams*.

(19) Non-nominal demonstratives as kind-denoting

- a. Degree: kinds of states → *gam3* in (1a)
- b. Manner: kinds of events → *gam2* in (1b)
- c. Quality: kinds of objects → *gam2* in (1c)
- d. State of affairs: kinds of worlds → *gam2* in (3a), etc.

It should be noted that the degree vs. manner distinction between *gam3* and *gam2* has been recognized widely (Sio & Tang 2007, 2008, Cheung 2013, among others). Arsenijević et al. (2015) further points out that *gam3* expresses an equality relation, whereas *gam2* expresses a similarity relation. The former concerns identity, and is *single-dimensional*, in a way similar to nominal demonstratives; in contrast, the latter concerns properties, which are *multi-faceted* (Umbach & Gust 2014; König & Umbach 2018). The above discussions can be summarized in Table 4.

Form	<i>go2</i>	<i>gam3</i>	<i>gam2</i>	<i>gam2</i>	<i>gam2</i>
Position	Adnominal + CL	Ad-adjectival	Adnominal + MOD	Adverbial	Clausal-final
Antecedent	Entity	Degree	Quality	Manner	States of affairs
Dimension	<i>Equative (single-dimensional)</i>		<i>Similative (multi-faceted; property)</i>		
Type	objects	kinds of states	kinds of objects	kinds of events	kinds of worlds
Example	(15)	(1b)	(1c), (13a)	(1a)	(3a), etc.

Table 4: Different kinds established by different demonstratives in Cantonese

The kind approach to SFP *gam2* contrasts with the apposition approach in that the former suggests a semantic effect of SFP *gam2*, to which I refer to as *the fuzziness effects*, informally stated in (20).

(20) The fuzziness effects of SFP *gam2*

The referent of the preceding clause of *gam2* must allow a certain degree of fuzziness, allowing *gam2* to refer to a set of similar clauses in the context.

The fuzziness effects triggered by SFP *gam2* has a number of desirable consequences. First, it explains why native speakers tend to agree that there is a pragmatic, softening effect on the proposition. For example, in (3a), the speaker tries to offer help in a less forceful way by making the offer a bit “fuzzy,” showing willingness to offer help or

something like that. The fuzziness effects also explain why SFP *gam2* tend to co-occur with *hoici* ‘likely’ in (13) and *gamgogksoeng* ‘feel.like’ in (15). The co-occurrence is reminiscent of Tang’s (2006) discontinuous constructions where SFPs are associated with pre-verbal elements with a similar meaning.

Second, the fuzziness effects provide an explanation on why SFP *gam2* is compatible with interrogatives, in addition to declaratives. Instead of being anaphoric to an interrogative clause, *gam2* under the kind approach allows sentences like (16) to construct a set of questions with the preceding clause being the most representative one. For example, the speaker of (16a) may be interested in knowing whether Zoengsaam obtains the book, and buying is the most obvious way, but the speaker is open to other ways, as long as the hearer can confirm whether Zoengsaam obtains the book. *Gam2* is used to construct a relatively vague question, subject to discourse contexts. Importantly, the fuzziness effects also predict SFP *gam2* is incompatible with sentence types that require discreteness and do not allow vagueness. For example, SFP *gam2* is disallowed in imperatives and exclamative, as shown in (21) and (22), respectively.⁸

(21) SFP *gam2* incompatible with imperatives

- | | |
|--|--------------|
| a. #Zikhak zau gam2 ! | Imperatives |
| Now go GAM2 | |
| ‘Leave now!’ | |
| b. Ngo soeng nei zikhak zau gam2 lo1. | Declaratives |
| I want you now go GAM2 SFP | |
| ‘I want you to leave now.’ | |

(22) SFP *gam2* incompatible with exclamatives

- | | |
|---|--------------|
| a. #Tou hei gei-gam houtai gam2 aa3! | Exclamatives |
| CL film really good GAM2 SFP | |
| ‘What a good film.’ | |
| b. Tou hei gei houtai aa3 | Declaratives |
| CL film quite good SFP | |
| ‘The film is quite good.’ | |

⁸ Here I assume the adverb *gei-gam*, literally ‘how-so’, and the SFP aa3 give rise to an exclamative construction, on a par with Mandarin *dou-me* ‘how-ME’ and SFP *a*, as discussed in Badan & Cheng (2015). One evidence comes from facticity, a signature property of exclamatives (Elliot 1974). Similar to *duo-me* in Mandarin (cf. Badan & Cheng 2015, (10b)), *gei-gam* in Cantonese resists embedding under non-factive predicates like *soengzidou* ‘wonder’, as in (i), in sharp contrast with (ii).

- | |
|---|
| (i) ??Aaming soengzidou tou hei gei-gam houtai aa3. |
| Aaming wonder CL film really good SFP |
| (Lit.) ‘Aaming wonders the film is really good.’ |
| (ii) Aaming zouzau zidou tou hei gei-gam houtai aa3. |
| Aaming already know CL film really good SFP |
| ‘Aaming already knows the film is really good.’ |

Third, while we have seen that SFP *gam2* can be embedded in subordinate clauses (cf. (14), not all subordinate clauses can take *gam2*. For example, *gam2* is disallowed in *only-if* conditionals in (23a) and unconditionals in (23b). I suggest that the former allows no fuzziness, as it highlights only one condition, and the fuzziness effects are vacuous in the latter, as it includes all relevant conditions. Both cases are in sharp contrast with (14a).

(23) *Gam2* incompatible with *only-if* conditionals and unconditionals

- a. #Zijau sik siusiu jatman **gam2**, sin hoji zaapbaan
only.if know a.bit Japanese GAM2 then can join.a.class.midway
'Only if (you) know a bit Japanese, (you) can join a class midway.'
- b. #Mouleon sik geidou jatman **gam2**, dou hoji zaapbann.
No.matter know how.much Japanese GAM2 DOU can join.a.class.midway
'No matter how much (you) known Japanese, (you) can join a class midway.'

As such, I conclude that not only should clause-final *gam2* be regarded as an event-type SFP, but its semantic function should also be construed as kind establishment, rather than the introduction of apposition structure.⁹

3. *Gam2joeng2* as a tag statement

This section examines yet another usage of *gam2*, more commonly used as *gam2joeng2*, as exemplified in (3b). Although it appears utterance-finally, I propose that it is not an SFP but a speaker-oriented, self-conformational tag statement. For convenience, I refer to this usage as tag *gam2joeng2*.

3.1. The distribution of tag *gam2joeng2*

Tags can be differentiated from SFPs in a number of aspects. Generally speaking, tags bear full clausal status, whereas SFPs are bound morphemes. It follows that tags exhibit the properties in (24).

(24) Grammatical properties of tags (Tang 2025)

- a. Tag are separated from the main clause prosodically.
- b. Tags may be used independently (free).
- c. Tags have SFPs.

In what follows, I show that tag *gam2joeng2* shows property (24a) and (24c), but (24b) is independently ruled out on semantic grounds, to which we turn in section 3.2.

⁹ Lee (2018) proposes that *gam2* carries the assertive force with updates the Common Ground of the discourse, but she offers different semantic characterizations when *gam2* is combined with declaratives, polar interrogatives and *wh*-interrogatives. The unified approach discussed in this section is thus superior to her proposal, which represents a non-uniform approach to SFP *gam2*.

As for (24a), not only does tag *gam2joeng2* follow many other SFPs (unlike SFP *gam2*), for example, SFP_{focus} *lo1* and SFP_{modality} *gwaa3*, but a pause is also typically found between the SFP and the tag. This is shown in (3b) and (25) below.¹⁰

(25) Tag *gam2joeng2* are separated from the main clause prosodically

- a. Nei jiu mai nei ling fanheoi lo1, **gam2joeng2** gwaa3.
you need then you take back SFP GAM2JOENG2 SFP
‘If you need it, then you take it back, maybe.’
- b. Honang gaazik gaaujuk wui beigaau tipgan gwaa3 **gam2joeng2** lo1.
maybe value education will relatively close SFP GAM2JOENG2 SFP
‘Maybe it is closer to value education.’

The same examples show that tag *gam2joeng2* can take its own SFPs, suggesting that it can carry independent illocutionary force. These observations suggest that *gam2joeng2* has a status closer to a tag, rather than an SFP.

Note, however, that tag *gam2joeng2* cannot be used on its own, unlike other tags, as in (26). It must be used after another utterance. As I will argue shortly, the dependence on the preceding clause follows from the core meaning of tag *gam2joeng*, which originates from the function of demonstratives as discussed in section 2.

(26) Utterance-initial position

- a. Hai-m-hai aa3?
Be-not-be SFP
‘Right?’
- b. #Gam2joeng.
GAM2JOENG2
‘That’s it.’

It should also be remarked that while tags are usually understood to be interrogative (Huddleston 1970, among others). It is possible that tags are declarative, as exemplified in English (27). I suggest that *gam2joeng2* is used as a tag statement, but it differs from English ones in its morphological encoding.

(27) Tag statements (Crystal 1985, p.476)

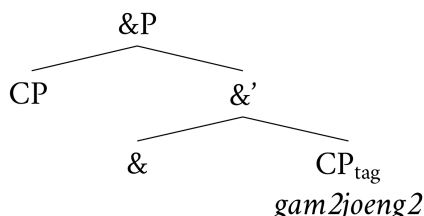
- a. That was a lovely drink, **that was**.
- b. He’s a nice man, **is John**.

Following Bill & Koev (2025) and Tang (2025), I suggest that tags involved a single, coordinated structure, which consist of the host (the first conjunct) and the

¹⁰ Examples in (25) are from the following sources:
(25a): https://www.lib.eduhk.hk/pure-data/pub/202402644/202402644_1.pdf (interview transcript)
(25b): <https://lihkg.com/thread/3652726/page/14>

increment (the second conjunct), schematically illustrated in (28). In terms of speech acts, the structure involves two independent speech acts of assertion.

(28) A schematic representation of tag *gam2joeng2*



3.2. The interpretation of tag *gam2joeng2*

Before I propose the meaning of tag *gam2joeng2*, it is instructive to reivew a similar expression in Mandarin, namely, *zheyangzi* ‘this.appeareance’, whose pragmatic functions have been documented in multiple works (see Huang 1999, Y.-H. Lee 2020, among others). Two examples are given in (29).

(29) Mandarin *zheyanzi* in utterance-final position

- a. Tingqilai hen qingchun **zheyangzi**. (Huang 1999, p.87)
 hear very pure ZHEYANGZI
 ‘It feels so pure as you listen to it. That’s all.’
- b. Wo dagai liu fenzhong jiu shuizhao le **zheyangzi**. (Tang 2015a, p.14)
 I probably six minute then sleep SFP ZHEYANGZI
 ‘Probably I will fall asleep in six minutes.’

The pragmatic functions are usually described as to “to mark a boundary in the discourse” or “to mark the end of a turn contribution” (Huang 1999, p.87), or “[to repeat] the main clause that precedes them and they are used to reinforce the meaning denoted by the main clause (Tang 2015a, p.14). Y.-H. Lee (2020) suggests that it is “a type of *discourse completion marker*, which marks the speakers’ emphasis on the finality or completion of the given discourse” (p.92), and it also “show the speakers subject distant from the story” (p.117).

I suggest that these descriptions fit equally well with tag *gam2joeng2* and that these functions can be derived if we assimilate *gam2joeng2* to confirmationals (Lam 2014, Wiltschko & Heim 2016, Yang & Wiltschko 2016; Tang 2020, Bill & Koev 2025). For example, the tags in (30) “request that the addresses confirm that the proposition expressed in the host sentence is true” (Wiltschko & Heim 2016, p.306).¹¹

¹¹ See also *ho2* in Cantonese (Law et al. 2018, Tang 2020) and *ha* in Mandarin (Yang & Wiltschko 2016).

(30) English tags as confirmationals

(Wiltschko & Heim 2016, p.306)

- a. You have a new dog, **eh?**
- b. You have a new dog, **don't you?**

The crucial difference of *gam2joeng2* from typical confirmational tags lies on the orientation of the tag. In particular, I suggest that *gam2joeng2* is a speaker-oriented, self-confirmational tag statement. Rather than requesting confirmation from the addressee, the speaker re-asserts, hence confirms, the truth of the preceding utterance. This gives rise to the effects as described in the literature. Upon the confirmation from the speaker, it marks a boundary in discourse, hence discourse completion. It also reinforces the meaning of the preceding utterance.

Such a construal of *gam2joeng2* has three empirical advantages. First, the self-confirmation function explains why *gam2joeng2* cannot be used on its own, unlike other tags. This is because it is always dependent on a preceding utterance *by the speaker* for confirmation. Non-self-confirmational tags can be used in a standalone way as long as there is an utterance by another interlocutor.

Second, it explains why *gam2joeng2*, as a tag *statement*, fails to stack with other tags, as in (31). This is because of the conflict of speech acts: *gam2joeng2* delivers self-confirmation, whereas *hai-m-hai aa3* 'right?' asks for confirmation.

(31) No stacking with other tags

- a. #Honang gaazik gaaujuk wui beigaau tipgan gwaa3 **gam2joeng2 lo1**,
maybe value education will relatively close SFP GAM2JOENG2 SFP
hai-m-hai aa3?
be-not-be SFP

Lit.: 'Maybe it is closer to value education. That's it. Right?'

- b. #Honang gaazik gaaujuk wui beigaau tipgan gwaa3 **hai-m-hai aa3?**
maybe value education will relatively close SFP be-not-be SFP
gam2joeng2 lo1.
GAM2JOENG2 SFP

Lit.: 'Maybe it is closer to value education. Right? That's it.'

Last but not least, like SFP *gam2*, *gam2joeng2* is sensitive to clause types, but it is only compatible with declaratives, as illustrated above, or with rhetorical questions.

(32) *Gam2joeng2* in rhetorical questions

- Mtong nei waa m dak aa4, **gam2joeng2**. (Luke 2000, p.309)
could.it.be you say not possible SFP, GAM2JOENG2
'Could it be that you say no? That's it.'

In contrast, *gam2joeng2* cannot follow interrogative clauses, not even questions with negative bias as in (33). I suggest that this is because declaratives and rhetorical questions requires the speaker’s commitment to the previous proposition, whereas interrogatives do not, and thus there is nothing to confirm from the speaker side.¹²

(33) *Gam2joeng2* in interrogatives

- a. #Nei gamjat soeng sik matje aa3, **gam2joeng2?**
 you today want eat what SFP GAM2JOENG2
 Int.: ‘What do you want to eat today?’
- b. #Aaming gamjat m lai me1, **gam2joeng2?**
 Aaming today not come Q.SFP GAM2JOENG2
 Int.: ‘Isn’t Aaming coming today?’

To sum up, this section discussed the syntactic status and the interpretation of *gam2joeng2*. It is syntactically similar to tag questions, but it differs from them in conveying the speaker’s confirmation of the preceding utterance, rather requesting confirmations from the interlocutor. It is thus best regarded as a tag statement for self-confirmation.

4. The cartographic footprint of *gam2*

Taking stock, I have argued that *gam2(joeng2)* has developed two usages that are understudied in the literature, namely its usage as an event-type SFP, and a tag statement for self-confirmation, summarized in Table 5.

	Syntactic status	Semantic contribution
SFP <i>gam2</i>	an event-type SFP in TP/CP	kind establishment
Tag <i>gam2joeng2</i>	a coordinated clause with the root clause	self-confirmation

Table 5 – Summary of the status of SFP *gam2* and tag *gam2joeng2*

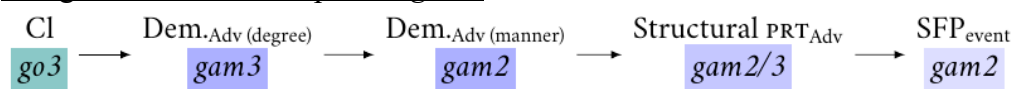
In what follows, I suggest that while both SFP *gam2* and tag *gam2joeng2* end up in the peripheral position of a sentence and contribute to discourse meanings, they achieve so via different grammaticalization paths. I also stress the role of apposition in the grammaticalization of *gam2* and *gam2joeng2*.

¹² Not all confirmationals are incompatible with questions. For example, *ho2* in Cantonese can be used with both declaratives and interrogatives (Lam 2014, Law et al. 2018). Law et al. (2018) argue that *ho2* is a higher-level interrogative operator that “operates at the level of speech acts ... asking whether the input speech act can be felicitously performed by the addressee” (p.1). Relevant to us is that tag *gam2joeng2* does not develop such a usage, attributable to the level of grammaticalization. It supports the proposal that it is indeed a tag statement, rather than an SFP.

4.1. SFP *gam2*: Upward successive reanalysis

It has been argued that the adverbial demonstrative *gam3* originate from the classifier *go3* (and *mat6* ‘thing’) in Cantonese (Cheung 2013, Lai & Wu 2020).¹³ Cheung (2013) suggests that *gam3* develops into *gam2* when it is combined with *joeng2* ‘appearance’ (which later becomes optional). Peng (2003), Sio & Tang (2007, 2008) further argue that both *gam3* and *gam2* have developed into a structural particle that introduces manner or degree description. I suggest that the observation that *gam2* develops into an event-type SFP is a natural extension of this grammaticalization path. (34) shows that how *go3* in the nominal domain evolves into the verbal domain, and later on into the discourse domain.

(34) The grammaticalization path of *gam2*



The path depicted in (34) basically follows what Roberts & Roussou (2003) calls *upward successive reanalysis*, where the status of *gam2* “climbs up” the clausal spine to the peripheral position of the sentence.¹⁴ Such a path is by no means unique to *gam2*, but is also observed with *de* (Simpson & Wu 2002, Tsai 2011b) and *wh*-expressions like *how*, *where* and *what* in Chinese (Tsai 2008, 2011a; Cheung 2009; Yang 2021, 2024; Tang 2022, 2026a, b).

There are two pieces of evidence in support of the grammaticalization of *gam2*. First, the development of *gam2* into an SFP resembles its development into a structural particle. In both cases, they start with an apposition structure (cf. Cheung 2007), as in (35). In both cases, *gam2* can be construed as an anaphor that takes *maamaafufu* ‘careless’ as its antecedent, or a functional element (i.e, a structural particle in (35a) or an SFP in (35b)). Cases like (35) thus serve as the bridging context in the grammaticalization of *gam2*, allowing for upward successive reanalysis.

(35) Apposition in adverbial and predicate positions

- a. Koei *maamaafufu* **gam2** zou-je m dak gaa3. Manner + *gam2*
 S/he careless GAM2 do-thing not possible SFP
 ‘He/She working in such a way is not acceptable.’
- b. Peter hai *maamaafufu* **gam2** gaa3. Predicate + *gam2*
 Peter be careless GAM2 SFP

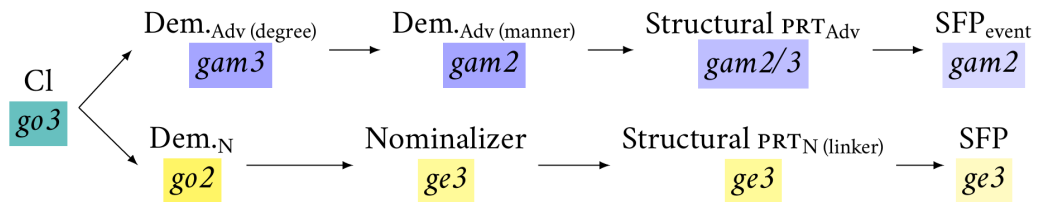
¹³ Lai & Wu (2020) differs from Cheung (2013) in that *gam3* does not develop from the nominal demonstrative *go2* ‘that’ plus *mat6* ‘thing’, but from the classifier *go3* plus *mat6* ‘thing’. They argue that demonstrative-noun sequence is disallowed in Cantonese, and thus it is more plausible that *gam3* is a reduced form of the classifier-noun sequence.

¹⁴ Roberts & Roussou (2003) suggest that “grammaticalization pathways can be deduced from the functional hierarchy (and possibly vice versa), once upward reanalysis is taken as a basic mechanism of syntactic change” (p.209).

‘Peter is like that.’

Second, it is instructive to observe a parallel grammaticalization path of *go3* in the nominal domain. It has been argued that the classifier *go3* turns into the nominal demonstrative *go2* and the nominalizer *ge3* in Cantonese (cf. Cheung 2006, Sio 2011). *Ge3* also leads a dual life as a linker in the nominal domain and an SFP, which further develops various variants, e.g. *ge2* and *gaa3*.¹⁵ For space reasons, I shall not replicate what is discussed about *go3/ge3* in the literature. The parallel path of *gam2* and *ge3* can be summarized in (36). The parallel development in the nominal and non-nominal domain shows that it is entirely unsurprisingly for *gam2* to become an SFP.

(36) The parallel grammaticalization path of the *gam2* and *ge3*



4.2. Tag *gam2joeng2*: From outer to inner

While it might be tempting to suggest that tag *gam2joeng2* develops from SFP *gam2*, I however argue that this should not be the case. In terms of interpretation, tag *gam2joeng2* maintains a relatively concrete meaning which has its roots in the anaphoric use of *gam2*. Its confirmational usage arises from the apposition usage that conjoins two utterances with independent illocutionary force.

There are also two empirical observations speak against the link between tag *gam2joeng2* and SFP *gam2*. First, as discussed in section 3.2, Mandarin demonstrative *zheyangzi* can also be used sentence-finally, with a similar meaning as tag *gam2joeng2*. Crucially, *zheyangzi* does not develop an SFP usage, at least not one comparable to SFP *gam2*. For example, *zheyangzi* cannot be used in interrogative clause, unlike SFP *gam2*, as shown in (37).

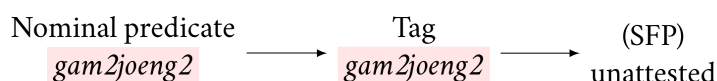
(37) Mandarin *zheyangzi* incompatible with questions (Counterpart of (16a))

*Zhangsan shi-bu-shi mai-le zhe ben shu **zheyangzi**?
 Zhangsan be-not-be buy-PFV this CL book ZHEYANGZI
 Int.: ‘Did Zoengsaam buy that book?’

¹⁵ This is also reminiscent of what Fung (2000) calls the mega word family, *G-*, whose core function is deictic, but it comes with various syntactic categories and additional meanings.

Furthermore, Tang (2025) discusses the possibility of grammaticalization from “outer periphery” into “inner periphery”, where standalone clauses are incorporated into its preceding clause through conjunction. Examples of this type include the H-family SFPs like *haa6waa5* (Tang 2025) and the W-family SFPs like *waa2* and *wo5* (Tang 2015b). What these SFPs have in common is the verbal origin, suggesting their former clausal status. Following the line of reasoning, I propose that *gam2joeng2* is in the early stage of grammaticalization in this direction, which has not fully grammaticalized into yet another SFP, unlike the H-family and W-family SFPs.

(38) The grammaticalization path of tag *gam2joeng2*



As such, the grammaticalization of tag *gam2joeng2* exhibits a different direction compared to SFP *gam2*. The former gets into the matrix clause via conjunction in the outer periphery, whereas the latter finds its way to the right periphery as a natural consequence of being appositional to the predicate. What is common between the two is, as I argue, the possibility of apposition of *gam2* at various levels, which is rooted in the core usage of demonstratives.

5. Concluding remarks

Building on works by Peng (2003), Sio & Tang (2007, 2008), Lee (2018), the current study examined two less discussed usages of the demonstrative *gam2* in Cantonese. In addition to its adverbial and clausal usages, I have argued that *gam2* can be used as an event-type SFP for kind establishment and *gam2joeng2* can be used as a tag statement for self-confirmation. Supplementing works by Cheung (2006, 2013), Sio (2011), Lai & Wu (2020), I also depicted the grammaticalization path of *gam2* and *gam2joeng2*. I showed that the two differs in terms of the directionality of grammaticalization.

As a final remark, while the demonstrative for degree description, *gam3*, is closely related to *gam2*, it does not develop an SFP usage nor a tag usage. Recall that the signature property of *gam2* is that it can be appositional to predicates and clauses, as shown in Table 3 in section 1. It is precisely because of this property *gam2* leads a different life compared to *gam3*. The absence of grammaticalization of *gam3* can further be regarded as indirect support to the current analysis on *gam2* and *gam2joeng2*.

Acknowledgements

TBA

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